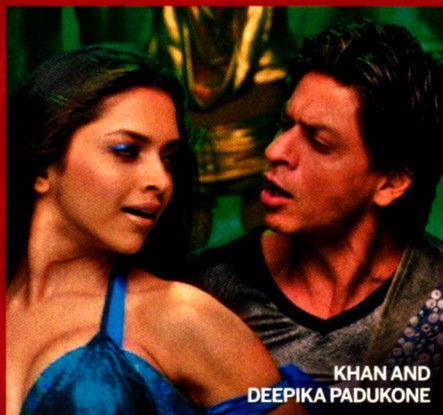


FILM REVIEW

BILLU

Simple Style



KHAN AND DEEPIKA PADUKONE

Director: Priyadarshan**Starring:** Shah Rukh Khan, Irrfan, Lara Dutta

It's a simple tale, told twice before in *Katha Parayumpol* and *Kuselan*, each time headlining a superstar. This time, it's Shah Rukh Khan, and he's playing Sahir Khan, a long lost friend of Billu from Budbuda village in Uttar Pradesh. Billu lives with his clothing-challenged wife played by Lara Dutta and his two children who don't seem particularly grateful. Put upon by the

villagers, flat broke, plagued by a cutting-edge hairdresser opposite, the best Billu can do is dream about the swivel chair he will buy. Priyadarshan's usual suspects turn up in full force, playing minor characters. There's Om Puri, playing a skinflint; Rajpal Yadav being a poet of sorts; and Asrani as, well, Asrani. I looked for Paresh Rawal but perhaps he was busy? Shah Rukh matches steps with three beautiful women, tells off a pushy politician type, dismisses all talk of Khan rivalry and cries for the last 20 minutes. The star resists the urge to hog the footage and Irrfan walks away with all the dramatic scenes, letting his eyes speak volumes, whether it is darning an umbrella or pretending to speak to a disconnected phone. So what's the take away from the movie? Stars, they're just like us? Not really, but occasionally they can let the story speak for itself.

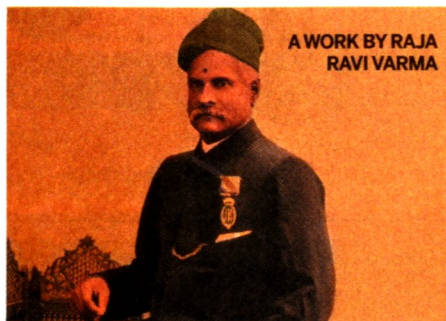
by Kaveree Bamzai

RATING ★ ★ ★ ☆ ☆

ART EXHIBITION

Gallery of FAME

The National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) opened in Bangalore mired in controversy and protests by local artists. The first in the south and the third in the country, the southern regional centre took nearly a decade to open house at the Manikyavelu Mansion. The gallery opened with a collection from NGMA titled Signposts of the Times, featuring prints, canvasses, paperwork and sculptures. Inaugurated by Minister of Tourism and Culture Am-



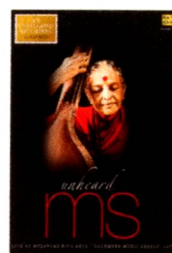
A WORK BY RAJA RAVI VARMA

bika Soni, it was said that the works being shown have not been seen anywhere else. These include pieces by artists like K.C.S. Panikar and Raja Ravi Varma.

by Nirmala Ravindran

MUSIC REVIEW

Hidden TREASURE

UNHEARD MS
Sa Re Ga Ma
Rs 300

It was this voice that Mahatma Gandhi lauded when he said, "To sing a bhajan is one thing; to sing it by losing oneself in God is different." In

this special unreleased recording of M.S. Subbulakshmi, she presents some of her finest renditions of raga, kritis and bhajans. The album begins with the famous Daru Varnam *Maate Malaya-dhwaja* in raga Khamas by Muthiah Bhagavathar. In her elaborate rendition of the rare kriti *Shri Chandrasekhara* in raga Shankarabharanam, Subbulakshmi takes amazing flights in the raga retaining the bhava throughout her recital. Other noteworthy tracks include *Challare Rama* in raga Ahiri and the sublime abhang *Sundara Te Dhyana* in Yamuna Kalyani. In the abhang, she keeps the melody of the song above lyrics and brings out its sweetness in the simplicity of its composition. No concert of Subbulakshmi's was complete without the bhajan *Maitreem Bhajata*. Her voice rings as pure and divine as it always was. Excellent accompaniment has been provided by Vikku Vinayakram on the ghatam and beautiful bowing interludes on the violin by K.S. Azhagiri Swamy. T.K. Murthy's mridangam and V. Nagarajan's kanjira provide the right rhythm.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit